

‘Growth will come from driving more online adoption’

Manish Tiwary, VP and Country Manager of Amazon’s India Consumer Business, explains how the e-commerce giant is planning to get its next 200 million customers in India, its playbook for the country and path to profitability

PHOTOS BY SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

42 |

A

After a decade of operations in India, Seattle-headquartered Amazon is setting its sights on the next 200 million users. With substantial capital investments and a commitment to digitising MSMEs and expanding the company’s omni-channel focus, Amazon’s profitability playbook for India is well on its way to success, says Manish Tiwary, Vice President and Country Manager of Amazon’s India Consumer Business. The 54-year-old reflects on the company’s journey over the past decade and shares its vision for the future in an exclusive interview with *Business Today’s* **Binu Paul. Edited excerpts:**

Q: How did Amazon manage to innovate for India and adapt strategies to meet the unique needs of the marketplace?

A: We were fortunate that the stakeholders in Seattle gave us not only the permission, but also encouraged

us to innovate for Indian customers and sellers. And therefore, what we created was ‘made for India and made in India’. We had the engineers and the ability to influence the marketplace, this stack and every aspect of the business. To take a few examples, 10 years ago, the mobile network quality [in India] wasn’t very good. We created a different app to solve the issue of latency. Very quickly, we moved into [local] languages. Right now, you can shop in seven [Indian] languages... A lot of people, back then, were not comfortable shopping online. So, we started a programme called Amazon Easy to establish a network of shopkeepers to help people shop online. More than 2 million customers came to Amazon via Easy. Before we came to India, we did not have ‘pay on delivery’... We wanted to quickly build trust with the customer [and so] pushed the fact that returns and refunds are very easy [when shopping online]. Now they sound commonsensical, but 10 years ago they sounded quite revolutionary.

On the seller front, a lot of them had never used a computer. For them, the first technology interface was the mobile. So, we had to create what was the first seller app on mobile. To familiarise sellers with cataloguing and other practices, we set up a seller university—a bank of videos on these topics. We also set up a system called Seller Provider Network where we would work with third-party agencies to train and help the sellers. We created Seller Flex, an exclusive fulfilment programme to keep track of sellers’ inventory. We had a small start, with around 100 sellers. We didn’t even have transportation logistics. Now, there are 1.2 million [sellers]. The one small warehouse has become close to 43 million cubic ft of storage space.

Amazon Pay, which was launched to close the gap